Diamila Disimban-Ramos

Diamila Disimban-Ramos (colloquially known as **Jam**) is a prominent Filipino legislator, women's rights advocate, and Maranao cultural leader serving as a Member of Parliament in the Bangsamoro Transition Authority (BTA). Appointed by President Rodrigo Duterte in 2019, she has become a central figure in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao's (BARMM) transitional governance, particularly noted for her advocacy in women's empowerment, social justice, and the preservation of Bangsamoro cultural heritage. As both a modern parliamentarian and traditional Maranao noble, Disimban-Ramos bridges institutional governance with the cultural responsibilities of her inherited leadership role, embodying what she calls "untainted public service" rooted in her deep commitment to her people's dignity and development.

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Early Life and Heritage

Diamila Disimban-Ramos was born into a lineage deeply embedded in Bangsamoro regional leadership. Her father hails from Taraka and Tamparan in Lanao del Sur, connecting her to the Maranao ethnic community, while her mother traces roots to Kabuntalan in Maguindanao and Pikit in Cotabato, linking her to Maguindanaon heritage. <ref name="heritage">Diamila Disimban-Ramos Official Profile, BTA Parliament. https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph/member-parliament/ramos-diamila-d/</ref> This dual lineage positions her uniquely across the major ethnic groups of the Bangsamoro region, granting her a comprehensive understanding of regional dynamics and shared values.

In November 2011, Disimban-Ramos underwent a formal rite of enshrinement as the **Bae a Labi a Gaus** (Great Queen of Wealth and Power) in Bubong a Masiu, Taraka, Lanao del Sur. This traditional title reflects her significant standing within Maranao socio-political structures and underscores her cultural responsibility to serve as a

mediator, keeper of communal honor (maratabat), and guardian of her people's welfare.<ref name="traditional">Disimban-Ramos 2011 Enthronement Ceremony Records, Taraka, Lanao del Sur. </ref>

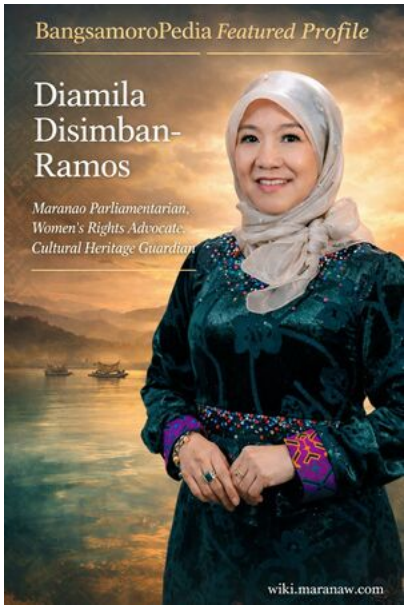
Education and Early Government Service

Disimban-Ramos earned her Bachelor of Science in Foreign Service, majoring in Diplomacy, from the Lyceum of the Philippines University, equipping her with formal training in international relations and diplomatic engagement.

Before her appointment to the BTA Parliament, she accumulated a decade of distinguished government service spanning multiple sectors:

- **International Diplomacy**: She served as a member of the APEC Substantive Group under the Department of Foreign Affairs during the 1995 APEC Summit, contributing to Philippine positions on regional economic cooperation.<ref name="apec">APEC Summit 1995 Delegation Records, Department of Foreign Affairs Archives.</ref>
- **Youth and Social Development**: From 1996 to 1999, she worked with the National Youth Commission, focusing on youth empowerment and civic engagement. Later, she served in the Cooperative Development Authority (2011–2016), where she promoted cooperative enterprise as an engine for grassroots economic development.<ref name="cda">Cooperative Development Authority Service Records, 2011–2016.</ref>
- **Regional Agricultural Development**: She served as the ARMM Focal Person for Agribusiness and subsequently as Chief of Staff at the Department of Agriculture and Fisheries (DAF-ARMM), driving initiatives to strengthen farming livelihoods and food security across the region.<ref name="daf">DAF-ARMM Administrative Records, Chief of Staff Unit.</ref>

Diamila Disimban-Ramos



Nickname	Jam
Born	Lanao del Sur / Maguindanao
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Maranao, Maguindanaon
Religion	Islam
Education	Lyceum of the Philippines University (Bachelor of Science in Foreign Service, Major in Diplomacy)
Political Position	Member of Parliament, Bangsamoro Transition Authority
Term	2019–present
Committee Leadership	Committee on Women, Youth, Children, and Persons with Disabilities
Traditional Title	Bae a Labi a Gaus (Great Queen of Wealth/Power) of Bubong a Masiu, Taraka
Appointment	President Rodrigo Duterte (2019)

Legislative Leadership in the BTA Parliament

Diamila Disimban-Ramos assumed office in the Bangsamoro Transition Authority Parliament in 2019, where she has shaped the institutional framework for the nascent autonomous region. Her parliamentary work centers on three foundational pillars: Sustained Peace, Effective Governance, and Empowered Constituencies.

Committee on Women, Youth, Children, and Persons with Disabilities

As chairperson of the Committee on Women, Youth, Children, and Persons with Disabilities (CWYCP), Disimban-Ramos has positioned herself at the forefront of gender-responsive governance in BARMM. She led critical public hearings on the Bangsamoro Gender and Development (GAD) Code, ensuring that regional policy reflects both international human rights standards and the cultural values of Bangsamoro communities.<ref name="gad">Bangsamoro Parliament Committee Minutes, CWYCP Hearings 2022–2023.</ref> Her leadership in this committee directly contributed to the passage of the Bangsamoro Labor and Employment Code (approved in early 2026), which aligns regional labor protections with moral governance principles grounded in Islamic values and democratic accountability.<ref name="labor">Bangsamoro Labor and Employment Code, BTA Parliament Third and Final Reading, 2026.</ref>

Key Legislative Measures

Disimban-Ramos has authored and co-authored several landmark bills addressing regional development, cultural preservation, and social equity. Her legislative record reflects a consistent commitment to institutional capacity-building and inclusive governance.

Ranaw Development Authority (Bill No. 111)

Perhaps her most significant initiative, Bill No. 111 proposes the creation of a Ranaw Development Authority to govern and rehabilitate Lake Lanao and its surrounding natural resources. This measure balances economic development with environmental preservation, addressing the ecological degradation of the lake while creating sustainable livelihood opportunities for communities dependent on its waters and fisheries.<ref name="ranaw">Bill No. 111, Ranaw Development Authority Act, BTA Parliament Archives.</ref>

Bangsamoro Cultural Heritage Act (Bill No. 204)

Co-authored with fellow parliamentarians, Bill No. 204 institutionalizes the protection and promotion of Bangsamoro history, identity, and arts. The measure proposes a Regional Registry of Cultural Property to safeguard intangible heritage including traditional weaving techniques (such as malong and ikat), oral epics (like the Darangen), and ceremonial chants that form the backbone of Bangsamoro identity.<ref name="heritage_act">Bill No. 204, Bangsamoro Cultural Heritage Act, BTA Parliament, 2021.</ref> This legislative approach treats culture not as folklore but as living intellectual property worthy of institutional stewardship.

Other Bangsamoro Communities Peace and Culture Centers Act (Bill No. 203)

Bill No. 203 seeks to establish regional hubs (Peace and Culture Centers) dedicated to the "Other Bangsamoro Communities" (OBCs), non-Moro groups and minorities living within and outside BARMM territory. The centers would provide social, cultural, and economic services while fostering interfaith dialogue and peaceful coexistence.<ref name="obc">Bill No. 203, OBC Peace and Culture Centers Act, BTA Parliament, 2021.</ref>

Bangsamoro Cooperative Act (Bill No. 210)

Continuing her long-standing interest in cooperative enterprise, Bill No. 210 empowers local communities and social enterprises to foster economic prosperity through cooperative ownership models, building on her prior work with the Cooperative Development Authority.<ref name="coop_act">Bill No. 210, Bangsamoro Cooperative Act,

BTA Parliament Archives.</ref>

Women's Economic Empowerment Act (Bill No. 292)

This measure specifically targets the economic uplift of former Bangsamoro women combatants, recognizing their sacrifice and contributions to the independence struggle while integrating them into civilian economic life through targeted support, skills training, and access to microfinance.<ref name="women_econ">Bill No. 292, Economic Empowerment of Former Bangsamoro Women Combatants Act, BTA Parliament, 2024.</ref>

Tamparan District Hospital Renaming (Bill No. 439)

In a gesture recognizing regional institutional growth, Disimban-Ramos filed Bill No. 439 to rename the Tamparan District Hospital to the Lanao del Sur Provincial Hospital, reflecting its expanded regional importance and role in provincial healthcare delivery.<ref name="hospital">Bill No. 439, Hospital Renaming Measure, BTA Parliament, 2025.</ref>

Role as Maranao Cultural Leader

Beyond her institutional parliamentary duties, Disimban-Ramos carries profound responsibilities within traditional Maranao governance structures. Her title as **Bae a Labi a Gaus** positions her within the socio-political order known as the **Pat a Pangampong sa Ranao** (Four Principalities of Lanao), a system of hereditary leadership that predates colonial rule.

In this role, she functions as more than a symbolic figurehead. A Bae a Labi is traditionally expected to mediate conflicts, uphold the maratabat (honor and rank) of her clan, represent her people in inter-ethnic dialogues, and serve as guardian of communal welfare. Disimban-Ramos integrates these traditional duties seamlessly with her modern parliamentary work, often viewing her legislative initiatives as extensions of her inherited cultural responsibility to protect and advance Maranao interests.<ref name="cultural_leader">Maranao Leadership Structures and Contemporary Governance, BTA Parliament Research Division, 2023.</ref>

Community Initiatives and Humanitarian Work

Disimban-Ramos is frequently recognized as a "fervid writer" and devoted Muslim mother who integrates personal values into her public service. Her humanitarian commitments extend beyond legislation into direct community engagement.

The **Strings of Aspiration** program stands as a defining example of her values in action. Through this initiative, she organizes regular feeding and gift-giving programs for Bangsamoro children in partnership with organizations like Save the Children Philippines, addressing immediate nutritional and material needs while building what she describes as "pathways of hope" for vulnerable youth.<ref name="strings">Strings of Aspiration Program Records and Social Media Documentation, 2022–2026.</ref>

Her commitment to what she calls "untainted public service" has earned her widespread respect among local leaders, civil society organizations, and military commanders alike, transcending the usual political divisions that characterize regional governance.<ref name="service">Disimban-Ramos Media Interviews and Public Statements, 2019–2026.</ref>

Personal Philosophy and Public Advocacy

Disimban-Ramos frames her legislative and humanitarian work around the concept of **Maratabat** (Maranao honor), understanding it not as historical nostalgia but as a living ethical framework for contemporary governance. She advocates for policies that recognize Bangsamoro agency in nation-building, resist what she terms "colonial residues" in national law, and center the voices of women, youth, and minorities in institutional decision-making.

In her public statements, she emphasizes that Bangsamoro empowerment is inseparable from women's empowerment, arguing that the region's post-conflict rebuilding cannot succeed if half its population remains economically marginalized or politically sidelined. This feminist orientation distinguishes her leadership from some of her counterparts and has made her a vocal advocate for gender-responsive budgeting and accountability within BTA institutions.<ref name="feminist">Diamila Disimban-Ramos Public Addresses, BTA Parliament Proceedings, 2020–2026.</ref>

Challenges and Ongoing Work

As a parliamentarian in a transitional authority, Disimban-Ramos navigates the inherent tensions of building democratic institutions in a region emerging from decades of conflict. Critics have occasionally questioned the slow pace of certain legislative initiatives, particularly regarding land rights and justice mechanisms, though she and her supporters argue that careful deliberation is necessary for sustainable, culturally grounded solutions.

Her work on Lake Lanao restoration, in particular, has faced resistance from entrenched economic interests, yet she continues to push for this measure, viewing environmental restoration as central to regional health and long-term prosperity.

Legacy and Future Directions

Diamila Disimban-Ramos represents a growing cohort of women leaders in the Bangsamoro region who navigate traditional authority with modern democratic practice. Her career demonstrates how inherited cultural leadership and formal institutional power can be integrated to serve broader peace-building and development goals.

As BARMM transitions from the Bangsamoro Transition Authority toward permanent democratic institutions, Disimban-Ramos's work on cultural preservation, women's economic empowerment, and environmental restoration will likely define her contribution to the region's foundational governance architecture. Her legislative record suggests a vision of Bangsamoro autonomy that is economically vibrant, culturally proud, and radically inclusive.

Recognition

Disimban-Ramos has been featured in regional and national media for her parliamentary work and humanitarian initiatives. She maintains active engagement with civil society organizations, academic institutions, and international development agencies focused on peacebuilding and regional development in Mindanao.

Further Reading

- Bangsamoro Transition Authority Parliament Official Archives: https://parliament.bangsamoro.gov.ph/
- Diamila Disimban-Ramos Official Parliamentary Profile
- BTA Committee on Women, Youth, Children, and Persons with Disabilities Records

- Save the Children Philippines Bangsamoro Programs Documentation

See Also

- Bangsamoro Transition Authority
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Maranao people
- Women in Bangsamoro Leadership
- Bangsamoro Gender and Development
- Lake Lanao
- Lanao del Sur

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